film or web series, audio projects take lesser time.

Amit Sadh, who had two different voices for Bruce Wayne and Batman, equates it to being like a "kid in Disneyworld". Some enjoy it so much that they can't get enough of it. Like Kubbra Sait, who has worked with Mugdh on two projects—*Mine & Yours* and *Aakhri Sawaal*—and recently played Death in the Hindi version of *Sandman*. "It's so quiet, all you are hearing is your own voice or the cues of the other person in the ears," she says. "I love that there are no sensory jerks in the middle of the process. You say something and you instinctively know that it didn't land." Sait credits her passion for the "spoken word" for her seamless fit in the audio universe. "It allows you to be a storyteller with voice modulation because you are drawing people into your universe," she adds. "The beauty of audio is that you are not only listening, you are closing your eyes and recreating the whole thing. What you are seeing is yours and yours alone. You can't see anything, yet you can see everything. It just depends how good your imagination is or how good you want it to be."

A LOCKDOWN LISTEN

OTT wasn't the only platform people turned to in the pandemic. As audio companies discovered, there was an audience for their wares too. "The pandemic allowed people to explore more, which aided the growth in the consumption of audio content," says Shailesh Sawlani, vice-president and country general manager, Audible India. "There was also an increase in 'escapist fiction' during the pandemic." Audio content went from a "nascent stage" to one with "potential to grow", says Unni Nambudripad, head, original podcasts and content development lead, Spotify.

Sensing the opportunity, audio streaming platforms started putting their money on it, if the two big April releases are anything to go by. Audible India's *The Sandman: Act I* in Hindi had Tabu, Varma, Manoj Bajpayee, Adarsh Gourav, Tillotama Shome and Neeraj Kabi besides Varma and Sait. Spotify hosted a big promotional for *Batman: Ek Chakravyuh* in Mumbai.

Content slates are going up too with shows in more languages, and a whole world of producers, directors, writers, sound designers, audio engineers and voice artistes is at work to meet the growing appetite for audio content. MnM Talkies specialises in the business, as do OfSpin Media and Audiomatic. Creators of video content are now foraying into audio territory as well, with Balaji Telefilms, The Viral Fever and Dice Media coming out with *Darmiyaan*, *Permanent Roommates* and *Pitching Pyaar*, respectively, all of which are available on Audible.



"THE ECOSYSTEM IS THRIVING. THERE'LL ALWAYS BE SITUATIONS WHEN YOU CAN'T WATCH SOMETHING AND STILL WANT TO BE ENTERTAINED"

UNNI NAMBUDRIPAD
Head, Original Podcasts & Content Development Lead, Spotify

HOW TO TELL A GOOD STORY

Sound acting is nothing new—even a parent reading out a story to a baby is doing so. "Your imagination takes flight," says Maggs. "Pictures emerge." Before video killed the radio star, it was the only means of information and entertainment. Sometimes the line got blurred, as it did with Orson Welles's *War of the Worlds* broadcast of 1938, when some of its listeners actually thought that Earth was under attack by Martians.

Effective storytelling will have to do all the talking if audio fiction has to succeed. At MnM Talkies, Mugdh and Mathur are using "3D binaural sound" for a more immersive experience that allows you to 'hear' the knock on the door or a pin drop. Mugdh foresees a day when "drama and cinema schools will have writing workshops for audio fiction writing". Cinema is written with visual references, says Mugdh. "An audio screenplay always needs to give out a dialogue reference to where you are and what you do. It is majorly based on conversations; they make for great audio plays."

For Batman, Mugdh and his team of writers ensured they didn't just translate the English script into Hindi but also tweaked it to appeal to the sensibilities of the Hindi-speaking audience, be it changing the Riddler's riddles or replacing Biblical and American cultural references with Indian ones. The adaptation does not stop there, the Hindi content then has to be taken to other languages. *Bhaskar Bose*, for instance, currently available in Bengali, is awaiting a Tamil and Telugu release. Nambudripad recalls how when *Bhaskar Bose* went on a four-month hiatus, Mugdh and he were bombarded with messages from listeners asking when new episodes would be out. "The ecosystem is thriving," he says. "There will always be situations when you won't be able to watch something and still want to be entertained." Keep your ears open. ■